

MINUTES OF MEETING HELD November 17th 2025 OF GRADUATE AND PROFESSIONAL STUDENT COUNCIL, GENERAL COUNCIL

A meeting of the Graduate and Professional Student Council (GPSC), General Council (GC) was convened on Monday, November 17th at 6:00 PM held in the El Portal Building Conference room and Zoom.

1. Call to Order & Land Acknowledgement

Present at the meeting were the following members of the:

- **(6) GPSC Executive Board (EB):** Mourad Abdennebi (President), Naama Levy (Administrative Vice President), Travis Dean (Executive Vice President), Mehrdad Aghayari (Assembly Chair), Milad Hasankhani (Treasurer), Rishabh Bhattad (Secretary)
- **(22) GPSC General Council (GC):** Anna Roche, Harriet Olulo, Max Thomas, Kinsey Clyne, Ella Stephan, Mohamadreza Ramenazi - proxy for Joanna, Breanne Harvey, John Conley, Theodore Lowell, J Bryce Palmer, Matt Sandoval, Nicole Perry, Esha Rajadhyaksha, Amanda Chriswell, Allison Colvard, Precious Innocent Mastala, Danaika Dorsainvil, Holly Thomas, Ryan Seal, Lucia Luna Aurelia, Hannah Szoke, Manglam Srivastav.
- **(5) Advisors and Staff:** Solange Quintana, Elham Chelabi, Roselyn Amamoo, Sabina Iturralde, David Bradshaw.

Quorum met: 26 Officers present

- The meeting began with the reading of the University of Arizona Land Acknowledgement.

2. Call to Audience

The GC may not discuss items that are not on the agenda. Therefore, action taken as a result of public comment will be limited to directing staff to study the matter or scheduling the matter for consideration at a later date.

3. Review and Approve Meeting Minutes

The minutes from the previous meeting (October 20, 2025) were reviewed and approved.

4. Officer Reports

- **President (Mourad Abdennebi):**
 - Reported a "huge win" for graduate students: The university has agreed to eliminate counseling fees for all students, effective Academic Year 2026-2027 (Fall 2026).
 - Noted a productive month with significant progress on advocacy goals,



- including the stipend increase (to be discussed in Old Business).
- **Administrative Vice President (Naama Levy):**
 - Announced that she will be stepping down from her role at the end of the semester as she is leaving her PhD program.
 - Reminded representatives that end-of-semester reports are due soon and a template will be provided.
 - Reminded representatives who have not yet attended a social event to do so to fulfill their duties.
 - **Executive Vice President (Travis Dean):**
 - Provided updates on ongoing program logistics, including inventory management and service requests for upcoming graduation events.
 - Reported on the status of communication with university partners regarding donation funds and account access.
 - Noted ongoing improvements to GPSC facilities and technology resources for student use.
 - Reminded representatives to complete required engagement forms.
 - Acknowledged Transgender Awareness Week and the upcoming Day of Remembrance, honoring lives lost to anti-trans violence.
 - **Treasurer (Milad Hasankhani):**
 - Reported that the second stipend payment is processing and expected to be disbursed by the end of the month.
 - **Assembly Chair (Mehrdad Aghayari):**
 - Discussed ongoing technology issues with the new meeting venue, noting that despite testing, audio quality for remote attendees remains a problem. Suggested one final test before potentially moving meetings back to Zoom.
 - Expressed concern regarding last-minute changes to meeting agendas and plans, emphasizing the need for consistency to respect representatives' time and expectations.
 - Recommended keeping long-term strategic goals (e.g., stipends, healthcare) as standing items under "Old Business" to provide regular, brief updates rather than re-introducing them as new voting items without sufficient detail.
 - Suggested forming small committees or assigning specific representatives to track these long-term goals to ensure accountability and progress.
 - **Secretary (Rishabh Bhattad):**
 - Reminded representatives to CC the Secretary along with Assembly chair on emails when assigning a proxy to ensure attendance is tracked correctly for stipend purposes.

5. Internal Committee Reports

- **Policy and Legislative Action (Elham Chelabi):**
 - Analyzing data from recently deployed surveys regarding student concerns and campus climate.
 - Organizing a meeting with the legislative office of Senator Kelly in Tucson and preparing for upcoming board meetings.
- **Appropriations and Grants (Roselyn Amamoo):**



- The committee has finalized decisions for current grant cycles.
- New grant opportunities are going to or have opened for applications for the next cycle.
- **Governing Documents (Travis Dean):**
 - The committee is actively seeking feedback on governing documents via a shared digital platform to improve clarity and support.
- **Marketing, Communications and Social Activities (Solange Quintana):**
 - Maintained regular communication channels through newsletters and social media.
 - Managing logistics for upcoming events and service programs.
 - Updated the website with current records and access links.
- **Professional Development (Naama Levy):**
 - Engaging with faculty experts to discuss workplace advocacy.
 - Collaborating with the library to expand resource access for graduate students.
 - Planning professional development services for the upcoming semester.
- **Elections Director (Sabina Iturralde):**
 - Introduced herself as the new Elections Director.
 - Working on the election timeline to ensure a smooth process leading up to the swearing-in date in May 2026.

6. Additional Reports and Summaries

- **Email Voting Results:** The Assembly Chair reviewed the results of two recent email votes, both of which passed:
 - **International Student Services Open Forum:** 10 Yes, 8 No. **Passed (56%).** GPSC will co-organize the event with ISS.
 - **Graduate Student Showcase:** 13 Yes, 4 No. **Passed (76%).** GPSC will host the showcase in the Spring.
- **Discussion on Email Voting:** A concern was raised regarding low participation in email votes (barely met quorum). Suggestions were made to use a distinct communication channel (like Teams) or clearer email subject lines to prevent voting requests from getting lost in inboxes. A reminder for the voting request 24 hours before the deadline was also discussed.

7. Old Business

- **Stipend Increase:** President Abdennebi announced that a 14% increase in the minimum stipend has been approved for the next academic year, raising the new minimum to approximately \$25,654. This increase is tied to the university's Cost of Attendance model. It was noted that there is no new central funding provided to colleges to cover this increase; instead, Deans must absorb the cost within their existing budgets and priorities though suggestions have been made to cover the additional cost via central funding. Moving forward, GPSC will collaborate on reviewing the Cost of Attendance data annually to determine future increases.

8. New Business & Action Items

- **Health Promotion:** Cassandra Hirdes, Director of Health Promotion, discussed



resources available to students, including nutrition, survivor support, and health education. She sought collaboration with GPSC to address specific graduate student needs such as loneliness, imposter syndrome, and self-compassion. Representatives highlighted a lack of awareness about CAPS services in the Law School, and Cassandra agreed to coordinate a visit. Additionally, it was announced that counseling fees will be eliminated for all students starting July 1, 2026 (FY27). Ideas for hosting wellness events like yoga and mindfulness were discussed, as well as utilizing the "Health Promotion Hideaway" in Bear Down Gym as a grad student space.

- **Graduate & Professional Students Success Spaces:** The Provost has agreed in principle to provide a dedicated space for graduate students in the Student Union, likely on the 3rd floor. The council discussed usage, reaching a consensus that it should be an open lounge/workspace for all graduate students (not just GPSC offices) but managed by GPSC. Card access was suggested to ensure the space remains exclusively for graduate students.
- **GPSC Advocacy Training:** Guests Daniel Curtis and Kaylynne Glover from FAARM (Framework for Accountability in Academic Research and Mentoring) presented their work advocating for better advising policies. They offered to host specific advocacy training sessions for GPSC members in December or the Spring semester. FAARM is currently assisting the Policy team in preparing for the meeting with Senator Kelly's office.
- **Meeting with Senator Kelly's Office:** A meeting is scheduled for Tuesday, November 18th, with Robert Guerrero, the South AZ Constituent Representative. The agenda topics will include funding, research support, and safety concerns.
- **ABOR Meeting at U of A:** The Arizona Board of Regents (ABOR) meeting is scheduled for November 20-21. There is a Call to Audience on Thursday morning at 9:00 AM. Representatives were strongly encouraged to attend and speak on critical student issues.

9. Constituency Concerns

- **Volunteer Opportunity:** A representative shared an opportunity to volunteer at the "Angel Charity for Children" ball on December 13th. This was presented as a valuable networking opportunity with Tucson donors for potential future GPSC fundraising efforts.
- **Student Services Fee (SSF) Budget:** Rep. Reza from the SSF advisory board reported that the budget for clubs (including ASUA and GPSC) might be doubled for the next fiscal year, potentially reaching approximately \$330k total. It was noted that further clarification is needed on whether this increase applies to the operational budget or the grants budget distributed by the SSF board.

10. Motion to Adjourn

- **Next Meeting:** The next General Council meeting will be held entirely online via Zoom due to room booking issues and holiday travel.
- Motion to adjourn the meeting by Mehrdad:
 - Seconded by Rishabh.
 - The meeting was adjourned at 7:20 pm.



THE UNIVERSITY OF ARIZONA

Graduate & Professional
Student Council

Dated this 17th day of November 2025

Graduate and Professional Student Council Executive Board

Rishabh Bhattad, Secretary